

CJ Rivas

Staff Frontend Engineer + Architect

Staff Frontend Engineer and Architect with 20 years of experience shipping consumer products at national scale. Deep specialization in React, TypeScript, and Next.js, with hands-on depth in AI-powered product experiences: LLM integrations, streaming UIs, MCP tooling, and agentic workflows. Has led frontend teams, mentored engineers at every level, and owned products end to end, from architecture and design systems through full-stack delivery and production operations.

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TECHNICAL SKILLS

TypeScript/JavaScript

React

AI Engineering/LLMs/MCP/Agents

Next.js

Vue.js

Node.js

Design Systems/Storybook

Micro Frontends/Module Federation

Tailwind/Emotion/Styled Components

Redux/Zustand

Vite/Webpack/Rollup

Monorepos/Turborepo/Nx

Jest/Vitest/Playwright

GraphQL

TanStack Query

Zod

Prisma

Headless CMS/Sanity

React Native/Expo

Supabase

Serverless/Edge Functions

Web Performance/Core Web Vitals

Frontend Observability/OpenTelemetry

Web Security/CSP/OWASP

Feature Flags/Experimentation

Accessibility/WCAG

SOFT SKILLS

Technical Leadership

Technical Communication

Cross-Functional Collaboration

Mentorship & Code Review

Product Thinking

Ownership & Accountability

Pragmatic Prioritization

Adaptability & Continuous Learning

Empathy for Users

WORK EXPERIENCE

— **Founder + Principal Engineer**
Codebender Inc.

01/2011 - Present
Part-time · Contract

- Founded and run an incorporated software practice, delivering senior/lead frontend engagements across news, finance, real estate, telecom, and SaaS, alongside a self-directed R&D track.
- Ship full products end to end — data modelling, API design, architecture, design systems, testing, CI/CD, deployment — primarily in React, Next.js App Router/RSC, and strict TypeScript.
- Standardize on Supabase as the default backend: Postgres with row-level security, auth, edge functions, and version-controlled schema migrations for reproducible environments.
- Work as an agentic developer: decompose features into specs and plans, drive them through coding agents in small increments with tests as the contract, and review every diff line by line.
- Build the harness for safe agentic development: convention files, agent skills, MCP integrations exposing repo/schema/design-system context, and pre-commit gates for formatting, type checking, linting, and tests.
- Enforce a consistent engineering standard across projects: strict TypeScript, boundary schema validation, co-located test coverage, referential-integrity checks in CI, and single-command quality gates.
- Ship cross-platform from single codebases — web, iOS, Android, desktop where warranted — deploying static/edge-rendered sites with image optimization and Core Web Vitals budgets.
- Use the practice as a proving ground for emerging tooling ahead of client adoption — runtimes, linters, build systems, rendering models, agentic workflows — forming grounded production opinions.
- Integrate LLM capability into product surfaces — streaming, structured output, tool use, retrieval — with attention to perceived performance, graceful degradation, and cost.

— Senior Frontend Engineer

09/2024 - 05/2026

The Globe and Mail

Full-time · Contract

- Owned the frontend architecture and delivery of an AI-assisted search experience on a national news property, integrating an in-house model API, streaming responses into the UI, and optimizing perceived performance so results felt instant despite model latency.
- Developed interactive React components integrated with a proprietary CMS on a consumer news property serving millions of monthly readers, improving reader engagement and streamlining editorial workflows.
- Built a Storybook-based design system for React components, strengthening consistency and team collaboration.
- Drove adoption of AI-assisted development across the team, embedding tools like Claude Code and Cursor into daily workflows and code review with clear guardrails, raising code quality and cutting review turnaround time.
- Mentored engineers through pairing, code review, and architecture discussions, and helped set frontend standards adopted across teams.
- Improved frontend maintainability through targeted refactoring and expanded unit test coverage.
- Integrated Sentry.io error monitoring into the frontend stack, surfacing production issues in real time and reducing time-to-resolution on reader-facing bugs.
- Partnered with product, design, editorial, and backend teams to ship reader-facing features on schedule across high-traffic surfaces.

— Fullstack Engineer

11/2023 - 07/2026

iPolitics

Part-time · Contract

- Serve as the sole full-stack developer for two Next.js/React/Prisma/Sanity news sites (iPolitics and QP Briefing), owning the frontend, backend, CI/CD, and infrastructure end-to-end.
- Diagnosed and resolved Sanity.io CMS issues, keeping both newsrooms publishing without interruption.
- Led a tiered TypeScript migration of both codebases, backed by Vitest test coverage.
- Implemented TanStack Query, Zustand, and Zod for data fetching, global state, and schema validation across a consistent, well-organized React codebase.

— Senior Frontend Engineer

01/2024 - 09/2024

XP Ventures Labs

Full-time · Contract

- Led the conversion of a legacy React JavaScript application into modular TypeScript micro-frontends, modernizing the architecture and enabling independent deployments.
- Migrated global state from Redux to Zustand and refactored components to modern React patterns, improving performance and reducing complexity.
- Designed and implemented a CI/CD pipeline with automated linting, formatting, unit, and E2E tests, accelerating development cycles.
- Championed TypeScript and React best practices through code reviews and updated team standards, elevating code quality.
- Reduced technical debt and optimized frontend tooling, improving developer experience across the team.

— Senior Frontend Engineer + Architect

06/2022 - 11/2023

Radian

Full-time · Contract

- Served as Frontend Lead Architect for homegeniusrealestate.com, owning the frontend end to end from zero to production with Next.js, TypeScript, GraphQL, and Nest.js.
- Delivered the complete real estate platform to market in under one year.
- Designed a scalable React design system with Storybook for component-driven development.
- Managed an NX monorepo with Docker and enforced standards through code reviews and mentoring.
- Collaborated with cross-functional teams on advanced search, interactive maps, and user dashboards.
- Optimized performance through code splitting, lazy loading, and efficient GraphQL queries, achieving superior Core Web Vitals scores.
- Reduced technical debt and established frontend best practices for faster development and long-term maintainability.

— Senior Frontend Engineer + Architect

01/2021 - 06/2022

Varicent

Full-time · Permanent

- Partnered directly with the CTO as frontend architect, setting technical direction and standards across multiple product codebases.
- Led a cross-project migration of React JavaScript components to TypeScript, establishing type-safety conventions that improved maintainability and reduced runtime defects.
- Rebuilt the build pipeline, replacing legacy webpack configuration with Vite and esbuild and cutting build times substantially.
- Consolidated projects into an Nx monorepo with custom tooling scripts, standardizing dependency management and streamlining the development workflow.
- Optimized CI workflows through job parallelization and dependency caching, shortening feedback loops for the entire team.
- Profiled frontend performance and implemented targeted optimizations against measured bottlenecks rather than assumed ones.
- Prototyped experimental modules and components to evaluate emerging frontend approaches ahead of production adoption.

— Senior Frontend Engineer

12/2020 - 02/2021

Myplanet

Full-time · Contract

- Developed an internal TypeScript toolset that streamlined website and application production by automating repetitive frontend tasks.
- Built a suite of reusable React component libraries to accelerate delivery across product teams.
- Maintained a Lerna-managed monorepo to coordinate versioning and dependency management across packages.
- Curated a Storybook-driven design system, organizing themes and themeable components to ensure visual consistency at scale.

— Senior Frontend Engineer

08/2020 - 12/2020

RBC Capital Markets

Full-time · Contract

- Engineered a real-time equities trading interface on React Hooks, TypeScript, and RxJS, modelling live market data as reactive streams with predictable update and cancellation behaviour.
- Authored comprehensive unit coverage across React components to protect correctness and stability in a low-latency, high-consequence environment.
- Established team code quality standards, integrating ESLint and Prettier into the development workflow and enforcing them automatically.
- Strengthened the DevOps pipeline with additional automated checks, accelerating builds and raising deployment confidence.

— Lead Frontend Engineer

08/2019 - 08/2020

RBC Ventures

Full-time · Contract

- Led frontend development on an internal administration platform, planning and delivering user-management capability end to end.
- Migrated the application from a legacy React architecture to a modern hooks-based architecture, reducing complexity and easing ongoing feature delivery.
- Improved measured and perceived performance through webpack chunking, lazy loading, and in-memory caching of frequently accessed data.
- Mentored incoming engineers and presented feature demos directly to stakeholders.
- Owned the CI workflow and authored custom tooling scripts that removed repetitive work from the development cycle.

— Frontend Team Lead

12/2018 - 08/2019

Toronto Star

Full-time · Permanent

- Led frontend development on thestar.com, a national news property, owning delivery of a new responsive primary navigation experience.
- Acted as final reviewer on pull requests and merges, holding the line on code quality, site performance, and user experience.
- Introduced E2E testing into the Jenkins pipeline and real-time error monitoring with Sentry, shortening time-to-detection on production issues.
- Diagnosed workflow bottlenecks and drove process changes adopted across the team.
- Interviewed frontend engineering candidates and contributed to hiring decisions.
- Delivered consistently against deadlines in an agile, continuous-delivery environment.

— Senior Frontend Engineer

05/2016 - 04/2018

The Globe and Mail

Full-time · Contract

- Built and maintained reader-facing features on a national news property in vanilla JavaScript, working without a framework in a large legacy codebase.
- Collaborated with the frontend team to deliver highly performant, responsive components across high-traffic surfaces.
- Implemented accessible semantic markup and advanced analytics instrumentation, improving both usability and editorial visibility into reader behaviour.
- Participated in code review and authored UI best-practice and code-standard documentation that became team reference material.
- Expanded unit test coverage across the codebase, improving stability and reducing regression defects.
- Delivered an internal Git workflow session to the engineering team, raising consistency and reducing friction in day-to-day development.

— Senior Frontend Engineer

01/2016 - 05/2016

theScore

Full-time · Permanent

- Built interactive features for a consumer fantasy sports application in Ember.js, working within the framework's routing-driven architecture and conventions.
- Contributed to iterative delivery in an agile team, participating in sprint planning and scoping.
- Reviewed pull requests and supported continuous integration workflows to uphold code quality.
- Expanded into server-side development through self-directed study of Ruby on Rails, broadening full-stack range beyond the frontend.

— Frontend Team Lead

11/2014 - 01/2016

Rogers

Full-time · Contract

- Led frontend development on a consumer-facing Rogers web application, establishing the AngularJS coding conventions subsequently adopted by every developer on the project.
- Designed a modular AngularJS framework that standardized how features were built and was adopted across multiple teams beyond the original project.
- Extended Bootstrap's AngularUI directives and documented frontend solutions, ensuring all delivered code carried unit test coverage.
- Built custom Node and Gulp modules to automate the build and development workflow.
- Conducted technical interviews assessing AngularJS depth, contributing directly to hiring decisions for the team.
- Mentored junior developers through hands-on pairing and code review, raising the technical baseline across the group.

— Intermediate Frontend Developer

04/2014 - 11/2014

Uptime Software

Full-time · Permanent

- Served as the sole frontend specialist on a company-wide infrastructure and server monitoring platform built in AngularJS, owning every frontend decision on the product.
- Established a test-driven development workflow using Jasmine, Karma, and Protractor, bringing automated verification to a codebase that previously had none.
- Consumed a proprietary RESTful API layer to build out the operator-facing interface for monitoring and alerting.
- Owned all frontend build tooling, authoring custom Gulp tasks to standardize the development and release process.
- Contributed shell scripts to the Bamboo continuous integration pipeline, automating steps previously performed by hand.

— Intermediate Frontend Developer

02/2012 - 03/2014

Kobo Inc.

Full-time · Permanent

- Contributed to Kobo's Instant Reader web application, built on the SproutCore framework, delivering features across the core reading experience for a global consumer product.
- Diagnosed and resolved frontend defects across the reading experience while shipping new capability in parallel.
- Partnered with design and UX to implement responsive layouts that behaved consistently across every supported platform and device class.
- Maintained and iterated on kobobooks.com, working in lockstep with backend engineers to deliver site-wide improvements.
- Collaborated across adjacent teams to investigate production issues and scope new feature opportunities.

— Senior Flash Developer + Team Lead

07/2008 - 09/2011

Research Now

Full-time · Permanent

- Architected a global Flash framework that powered the company's custom survey tooling across international markets, standardizing delivery across regions.
- Led the North American Flash team, mentoring junior developers and setting the technical standards the team built against.
- Engaged directly with clients to gather requirements and scope custom work, translating commercial needs into technical delivery plans.
- Authored a proprietary ActionScript 3 library grounded in object-oriented principles, eliminating duplicated effort across internal projects.
- Delivered a Flex-based real-time reporting application that surfaced live respondent data to stakeholders as surveys ran.

AWARDS

Service Excellence - FE

mobileLIVE · 2015

Above and Beyond

The Globe and Mail · 2017

LANGUAGES

English

Native or Bilingual Proficiency

Spanish

Native or Bilingual Proficiency

EDUCATION

Digital Media Arts

Seneca College of Applied Arts and Technology